During periods of rapid growth the body's need for iron increases. Children 6- 24 months old are at the greatest risk of irreversible long-term consequences of iron deficiency like impaired physical and mental development. To meet this increased demand for iron, iron rich foods like rice flakes, dates, egg yolk and greens should be included in the diet.

3.1.2 Diet for the preschool child

The nutritional requirements of the child cannot be satisfied apart from an understanding of behavioral changes that occur. Toddlers begin to show independence and to assert themselves. They are alert to the attitudes of others and readily learn that they can use food as a weapon to gain attention. They mimic siblings and parents. They have short attention span and are easily distracted from eating. Their response to food is often inconsistent

Dietary guidelines for a preschool child

- The diet of the preschoolers should be adequate in quantity and quality of different nutrients. In addition to the amount of milk recommended, the preschool child should have two small servings of protein-rich foods like eggs and other non-vegetarian foods like pulses, paneer or cheese.
- When the child is about 18 months old finger foods such as carrots can be given.
- Proper elimination is usually maintained by a daily diet of fruits, vegetables and whole grain products.
- The diet should include a wide variety of foods. The child who is taught to eat everything on his plate is much more likely to enjoy optimal health than the one who picks and chooses
- Their food intake will improve if the food is interesting and attractive. e.g. chapathis, puris can be made into shapes or can be served in attractive plates. Flavour or colour of the milk can be changed to encourage the child to drink milk.
- Foods should be slightly seasoned so that they taste better and the child takes it well.
- Food preferences of the child should be taken into consideration.
- Child should never be forced to eat more than he can take.
- The person feeding the child should not show any dislike of the food in front of the child.
- The child should never be hurried while taking the food. The atmosphere should be pleasant and lacking distraction
- Regularity of meal times is essential
- Unripe bananas and fruits should not be given as they are difficult to chew and may choke the child.

3.1.3 Common feeding problems in children

Avoidant/Restrictive Food Intake Disorder is a common eating disorder experienced by young children. Children with this disorder experience a disturbance in their eating which can include a lack of interest in food or a sensory aversion to certain foods

- Eating only certain types of foods
- Refusing vegetables
- Refusing to chew
- Taking a long time to eat and keeping food in the mouth (rumination)
- The toddler/child wants to choose his own food.
- **Pica** is a type of condition where a child might eat non-food or non-nutritional substances persistently. These substances often include dirt, soap, chalk, sand, ice, and hair.

These aversions and restrictions can lead to weight loss and nutritional deficiency among young children.

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